REAL RECOGNIZES REAL:

Adolescents on Authentic Inclusive Representation in Film Franchises



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CENTER FOR SCHOLARS & STORYTELLERS @ UCLA

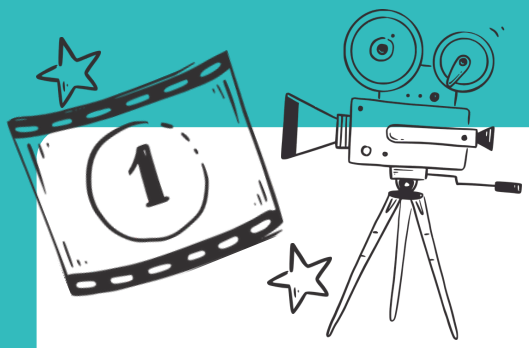




TABLE OF CONTENTS

Introduction 3

Definitions 5

Main Findings 6

Finding One: Gen Z picks winners 7

Adolescent ratings of representation predict box office success..... 7

Finding Two: Lived experience is the strongest signal 9

Adolescents rating their own identity are the best predictors 9

Finding Three: Lessons from Gen Z 11

Three “fatal flaws” in representation 12

Centering relationships can drive good representation 15

Conclusion 16

Concrete Tips for Better AIR 17

Methods 18

Acknowledgments 20

References..... 21

How to Cite This Report:

Puretz, M., Ibarra, H., Abazari, L., Hines, A., & Uhls, Y. T. (2025). Real Recognizes Real: Adolescents on Authentic Inclusive Representation in Film Franchises. Center for Scholars & Storytellers. https://www.scholarsandstorytellers.com/air-adolescents

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INTRODUCTION

“When writing characters, especially characters who are not White, cis, straight, or able-bodied, there seems to be a lack of depth given to them. These characters meant to "represent" us end up coming off as flat, squeaky-clean versions of our communities, when in reality, no one is like that! Diversity is about authenticity and truth. And sometimes that's messy. Show us the mess!”

- Ana Borrego, 19, Latina, California

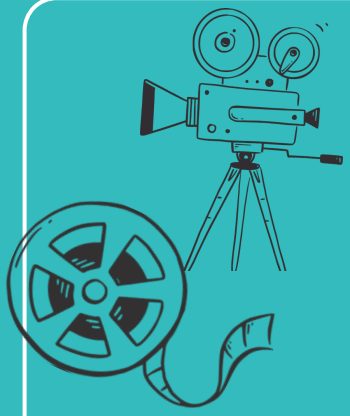
Franchises remain the financial engine of the film industry - and young audiences are the fuel. In 2025, more than half (53%) of films made by the seven major studios were franchises, including most of the higher-budget films. Since this trend will likely continue – after all, 9 of the 10 highest-grossing films of 2025 were franchises – it’s worth better understanding what makes franchises work: young audiences. Young people are often the core demographic for franchises: they engage strongly with their fandoms long-term and love to see movies during opening weekends, both of which help drive franchises’ success. And Gen Z (around age 13 to 28) were the most common moviegoers; in 2025, they made up **39 percent** of the North American movie audience. It’s not surprising then that the two biggest domestic box office successes in 2025 were carried by young audiences: The Minecraft Movie, an adaptation of a game beloved by Gen Z, and Lilo & Stitch, a nostalgic live action remake aimed at older Gen Z moviegoers.

What do young audiences want from franchises? The box office data gives us one potential answer: **diverse representation**. Adolescents today are more racially diverse than any prior generation, more likely to identify as LGBTQ+, and more likely to have grown up alongside peers from different backgrounds, and it shows. According to the UCLA Hollywood Diversity Report, films with more diverse casts make more money: for instance, films with casts that were between 40% and 50% people of color (the U.S. population is 45.2% people of color) **made more than double their budgets on average**, while films with casts that were at least 90% White lost money on average. This pattern of success for more diverse casts has been consistent across years of data for domestic and global box office earnings. Yet studios have been wary of backing these projects with higher budgets: diverse representation in film is often concentrated in lower-budget, non-franchise films. The breakdown of 2024 films by the lead's identity illustrates this pattern:

- Only **42.3%** of POC-led films had budgets over **$30 million**
- Under half **42.9%** of White woman-led films had budgets over **$30 million**
- Nearly three quarters **(71.4%)** of White man-led films had budgets over **$30 million**

In other words, many films that star a person of color or a woman are smaller-budget films, while larger budget films, which includes most franchises, tend to have White male leads. Studios are hesitant to fully embrace diversity in franchises, likely because they perceive diversity as risky.

In this study, we wanted to test if asking adolescents could reduce that risk and make the success of diverse projects more predictable. Adolescents (ages 13-24) today are not only more diverse than any prior generation, they have also grown up in a media environment that shows more diversity than previous generations got to see. All that exposure builds fluency. We would expect that adolescents, despite their age, are savvy consumers of media with representation of people of color, LGBTQ+ people, and women. So we asked them about representation in franchises ourselves, and compared that to franchise box office success. The real question we wanted to know: **can asking adolescents about representation help studios make hit franchises?**



About Our *Authentically Inclusive Representation* Research

This project is the latest in our Authentically Inclusive Representation (AIR) series. Previous reports have found that authentically inclusive representation, as rated by advocacy groups like GLAAD, Better Life Labs, Geena Davis Institute, and NHMC, leads to box office success - as well as higher critical and audience ratings of movies and shows. Our Roadmap to AIR report lays out 10 actionable tips to create a production process that leads to more authentic representation. Click here to read our AIR reports.

ABOUT THE CENTER FOR SCHOLARS & STORYTELLERS

The Center for Scholars & Storytellers (CSS) at UCLA is a nonprofit that brings together the academic and creative communities to unlock the power of storytelling and help the next generation thrive and grow. Our primary aim is to support storytellers who are working towards better reflecting the lives of kids, teens and young adults. CSS is affiliated with UCLA through the faculty appointment of our founder, Dr. Yalda T. Uhls, in the Psychology Department, one of the highest-ranked in the world. We have more than 100 academic collaborators from universities around the world. Our award-winning work has been featured on NPR, the New York Times, the Los Angeles Times, Deadline, Good Morning America and more. CSS is the only organization with the institutional affiliation, the academic credibility and the entertainment expertise that meets youth where they are: on screens. Learn more about our work at ***scholarsandstorytellers.com.***

Definitions

Adolescents: In this report, we consider adolescents to be young people aged 13 to 24, but we acknowledge that many neuroscientists and developmental psychologists now consider adolescence to extend from ages 10-24. Note: In some places in the report, we use "Gen Z" as a shorthand for adolescents, but there is a small difference between the two groups; when the data were collected, Gen Z was considered to be people aged 13 to 28.

Authentic Inclusive Representation: For participants, we defined this as, "Authentically inclusive representation of [identity group] people means portraying both [identity group] individuals and their culture prominently in the movie, in a way that is genuine and respectful. This means a [identity group] viewer would feel understood by the movie, seeing themselves and their culture accurately represented."

Diverse Representation: When we use this term in this report, we are referring to representation of people with marginalized identities, including people of color, women, and LGBTQ+ individuals.

Lived Experience: Living with an identity (e.g. Latino/a/e or LGBTQ+ identities) and gaining knowledge of and expertise around that identity through personal experience rather than exclusively through learning about the identity from other people.

Film Franchises: Films that have other media properties within the same IP, including multiple films. For example, the franchises in our dataset were: Avatar, Barbie, Black Panther, Blue Beetle, Bob's Burgers, Captain Marvel, Coco, Crazy Rich Asians, Creed, Doctor Strange, Downton Abbey, Fantastic Beasts, Fast & Furious, Frozen, Incredibles, Knives Out, Minions, Moana, Ocean's Eight, Spider-Verse, Strange World, The Batman, The Color Purple, The Hunger Games, The Jungle Book, Thor, Tyler Perry's Madea, Ultraman: Rising, Wreck-It Ralph.

Special thanks to our project partners:

Project data was collected in partnership with National Research Group (NRG), which integrated our survey questions into their Franchise IQ national survey.

Support for this research was provided by the Funders for Adolescent Science Translation (FAST).

Data Powered By: nrg

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Key Takeaways



1 Gen Z picks winners

- On a scale of 1 to 5, for every point higher adolescents rated the representation of people of color, women, or LGBTQ+ people in a franchise, the franchise made $175.5 million more at the box office
- Adolescents ratings are unique barometers of success - expert consultants aren't enough

2 For young people, lived experience is the strongest signal

- Adolescents rating representation of their own identity predicted box office success **65% better** than adolescents rating identities they don't share
- Adolescents with lived experience of an identity seem to be experts on representation of that identity by age 13

3 Lessons from Gen Z

- According to adolescents, three things can doom the representation of an identity: (1) A lack of cultural representation, (2) minimal roles for diverse characters, and (3) unrelatable diverse characters
- But centering the relationships between diverse characters can help adolescents connect to them and bring cultural representation to life
- More authentic representation leads young people to connect more with the film's characters, which can help drive financial success for franchises



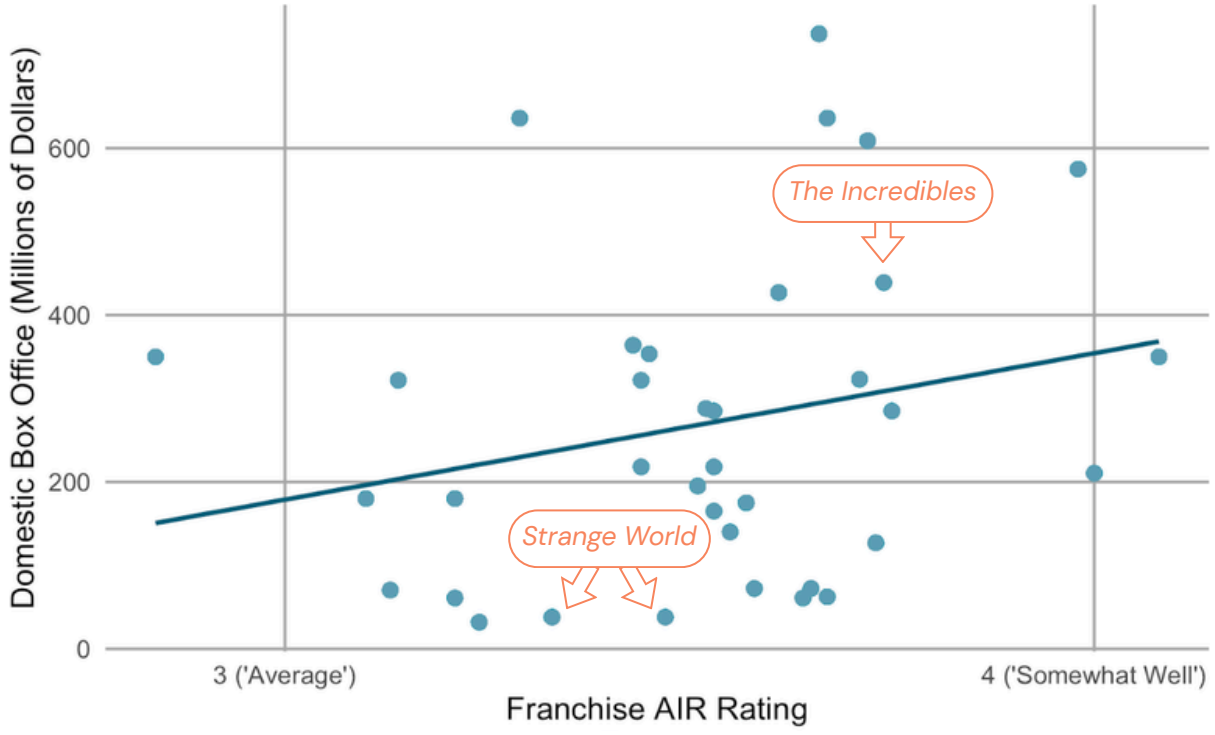
Read on for the full findings and more insights!

Research Finding #1

Adolescents pick winners

The more positively that adolescents rated the representation of people of color, women, or LGBTQ+ people, the more box office success the franchise had

$175.5 million the difference in average box office earnings per movie between a franchise that adolescents said represented a diverse identity in an "**Average**" way (3 out of 5) and one that represented it "**Somewhat well**" (4 out of 5). We found this pattern across types of representation and movie genres, so we expect that the pattern would continue beyond these types of identities. In other words, portraying a diverse identity well enough that adolescents consider it **above-average representation really pays off**.



For instance, adolescents felt that *Strange World*, which grossed just $38 million at the domestic box office, does not rate highly either for its depiction of women (3.47/5.00 on average) or LGBTQ (3.33/5.00) characters. By contrast, adolescents rated the representation of women in *The Incredibles* franchise, which brought in an average of $435 million per movie in domestic earnings, pretty highly (3.72/5.00), especially the Violet character. This example illustrates how much these findings hold true even for the identities of supporting characters – **authentic representation pays off across roles.**

Isn't it enough to just ask expert consultants about representation?

No – Adolescents are unique barometers of success

When we recalculate the previous graph and control for ratings from adult experts, higher ratings of representation from adolescents were still strongly associated with box office success. This means that adolescent perspectives add **unique predictive power** that expert consultants would not otherwise provide. In other words, it's not enough to consult experts on representation: **studios would minimize risk and maximize box office earnings if they consulted and screen-tested with adolescents**!

Consult both consultants and adolescents

Just as expert consultants cannot speak for adolescents, the opposite is also true - studios should consult both. Multiple generations of AIR reports have shown us that **expert ratings of representation strongly predict box office performance**. Consultants are essential, helping hone the cultural specificity and avoiding missteps that help representation feel authentic: research shows that it pays to have consultants bring their expertise to projects from the beginning of the production process. To have the great representation that drives box office success, integrate both the expertise of consultants and the lived experience of adolescents into your project.

Context Corner: In our recent Teens & Screens report, we found that adolescents rank "people with lives like my own" as the number 1 topic they want to see in the media. **For adolescents with diverse identities, that means authentic representation.** But other adolescents want to see diverse representation too: Deloitte Research found that nearly 70% of audiences want to watch media that can "help them learn about cultures different from their own". If it's authentic, diverse representation has very broad appeal.



Research Finding #2

For adolescents, lived experience is the strongest signal.

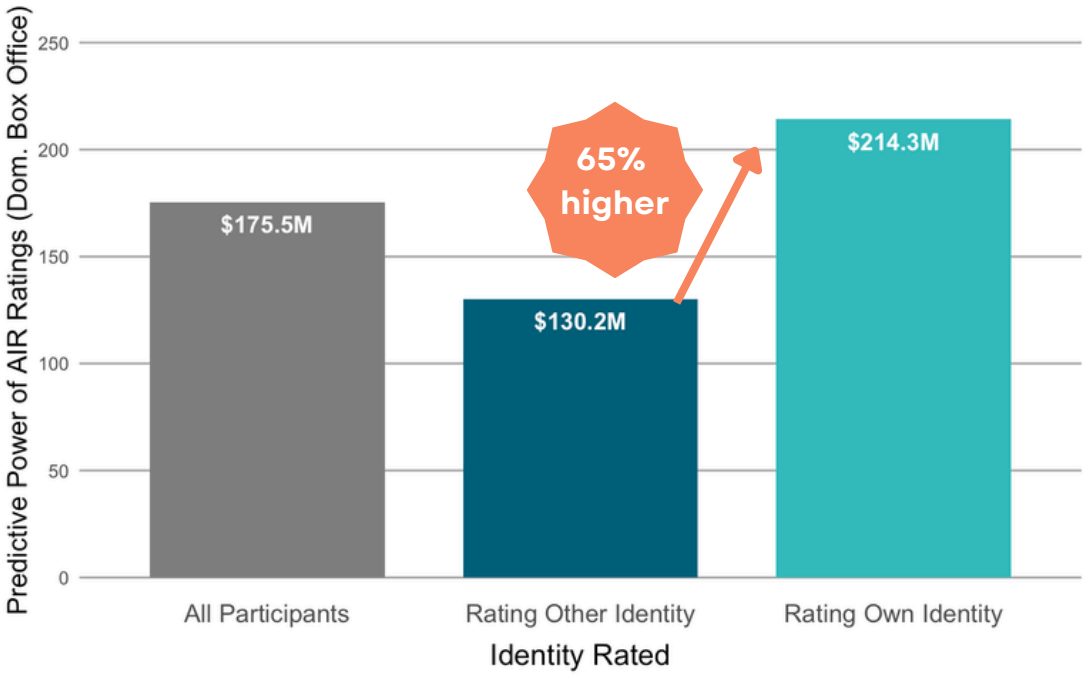
The importance of having lived experience (in other words, having the relevant identity) is clear from the data – they are experts, even at a young age. Ratings from adolescents who share the identity they were rating predicted box office success 65% better than adolescents rating identities they don't share

$214.3 million

the difference in average box office earnings per movie between a franchise that adolescents with lived experience said represented their own identity in an "**Average**" way (3 out of 5) and one that represented it "**Somewhat well**" (4 out of 5).

By comparison, adolescents rating other identities they don't share were still worth listening to. For adolescents rating an identity they don't share, when they rated a franchise a 4 ("Somewhat well") instead of a 3 ("Average"), the franchise made only an extra **$130.2 million** per movie. The difference in the predictive power of the two groups ratings can be seen in the graph below comparing adolescents **rating another identity** to adolescents **with lived experience**:

Adolescents with lived experience (rating their own identity) are the best at identifying authentic inclusive representation that leads to box office success. The average for all participants (Finding #1) is shown for reference.



Is asking a 13-year old about representation actually worthwhile?

Yes - especially if they have lived experience with the identity

Our data show that adolescents as young as 13 gave representation ratings similar to 24-year-olds, but **only if they both shared the identity being portrayed**. As they age through their teenage years, adolescents rating an identity they *don't* share start to agree more with experts, because they're learning about representation. But adolescents with lived experience (rating their own identity) do not align themselves with experts more, because they already had their own expertise by age 13.

Did you know?

Diverse representation tends to perform well overseas! Despite a common misconception to the contrary, CSS research has shown that around three-quarters (75%) of international audiences want to see films about cultures other than their own. Work from USC Annenberg has shown that films with both leads who are people of color and more racial diversity overall tend to make more money in overseas markets than films with less racial diversity or White leads.

The key takeaway is this:

While most adolescents are knowledgeable about authentic representation, having lived experience with a particular identity gives adolescents real expertise, as early as age 13. Even more than other adolescents, younger adolescents with lived experience have unique, informed opinions about representation.

> "Authentic content resonates when it portrays real emotions, relatable struggles, and diverse characters who talk and act like people I know."
> – Girl, 13, White, California

Want input on your project from diverse adolescents?

As part of our core mission, CSS's **Youth Media Representation (YMR)** Program provides opportunities for youth to shape media by conducting research among their peers and training them to review scripts, provide notes, and speak directly to the people who create stories for and about youth. Bringing a diverse array of perspectives from different racial, gender, LGBTQ+, and geographic backgrounds, they consult with many major studios. Learn more about how YMR can help here.

Research Finding #3

Lessons from adolescents: Three "fatal flaws" and how authentic relationships help

To better understand their unique perspectives, we looked closer at what specific characteristics of diverse representation adolescents are tuning in to.

The three fatal flaws

After rating the representation in each franchise, adolescents identified its main flaw. **There were three "fatal flaws" that adolescents associated with poor representation:**

1. **A lack of cultural representation of that identity**
2. **Minimal role(s) for characters with that identity**
3. **Characters with that identity are not relatable or realistic**



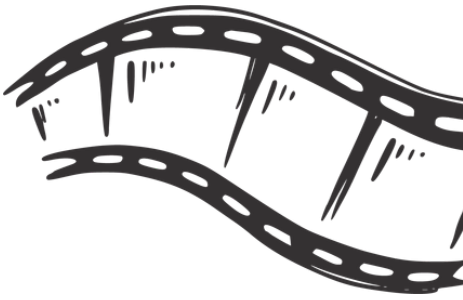
What makes these flaws "fatal"?

On average, if two adolescents rated the same franchise and one felt like the main flaw was a fatal flaw (e.g. a lack of cultural representation) and the other was not (e.g. a stereotypical character), t**he adolescent who noted a fatal flaw would consistently rate the franchise's representation lower**.



Do adolescents agree on which flaws are fatal?

Adolescents with lived experience (who shared the identity they were rating) and those without agreed on these six flaws. **Both groups put the flaws in the same order and associated the top three with low-rated representation.** This consensus emphasizes the importance of these three fatal flaws across the board.



A deeper dive into the three fatal flaws:

A lack of cultural representation

Although the focus is often on portraying a diverse character *positively*, adolescents look deeper, judging whether the character actually feels like a real person with that identity. That starts with whether aspects of their culture are infused into the story in an authentic way. When a character's culture is accurately grounded in their culture and its values, attire, food, music, and language, that character is much more likely to feel authentic to young people.

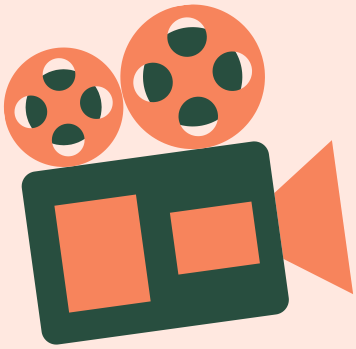


Spotlight: Black Panther

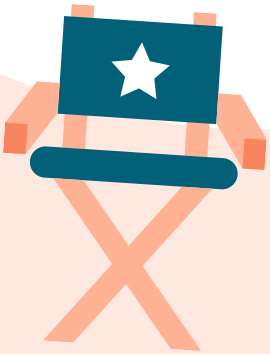
For example, the *Black Panther* franchise is a superhero franchise, but it incorporates elements of African culture and Afrofuturist ideas with enormous care. The franchise is very intentional about including nuggets of African culture throughout the films, from the traditional stacked neck rings in the wardrobe to the use of the South African language Xhosa in dialogue. Instead of the culture being a trait of the character, it is integrated into the world itself. In our data, experts rated *Black Panther* somewhat highly, but young audiences rated it very highly – **the third highest rated franchise overall**. The cultural elements resonate with young audiences, and unsurprisingly, the franchise has been incredibly successful. For more info on cultural representation, see the roadmap to AIR.

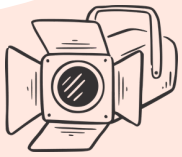
Minimal roles for characters

Adolescents also associated franchises that gave minimal roles to characters with the relevant identity with poor representation. For example, if the character has a minimal impact on the plot, gets sparse characterization, lacks any story arc, or simply does not get to speak or be seen on screen much, they probably have a minimal role, and for adolescents that can really undermine a portrayal of a diverse character. In our data, this is best exemplified by LGBTQ representation, as we explore below.



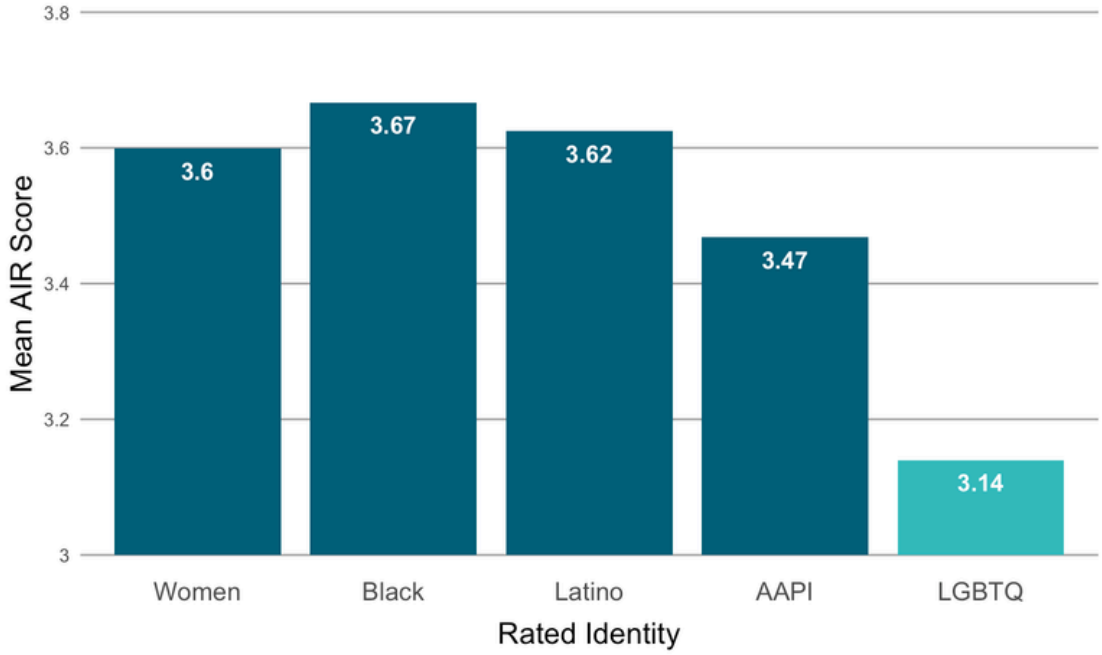






Lowlight: LGBTQ+ representation

To illustrate this fatal flaw, we'll look at LGBTQ+ representation, which is by far the lowest rated identity in the sample. Experts agreed with adolescents - they rated LGBTQ+ representation lower than any other type of representation in these 29 franchises.



Note: There was only one rated film for Native/Indigenous representation in the dataset (Moana), too small of a sample to draw any broader conclusions about Native/Indigenous representation, so we omitted it from this graph.

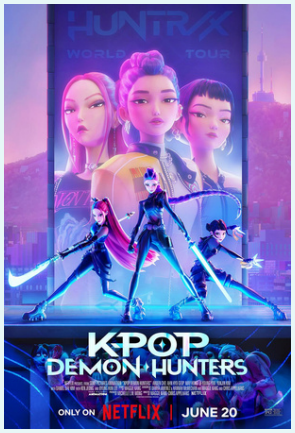
Although there are a number of examples of authentic LGBTQ+ representation in film, it still lags behind in big-budget films like the franchises examined in this study. As noted by GLAAD's Studio Responsibility Index, LGBTQ+ representation in studio films are often **minor characters with little screen time**, who are mainly there to serve the central character(s). Adolescents flag minimal roles, so it's no coincidence that they rate LGBTQ+ representation in franchise films - in fact, all of our five lowest rated representations in our franchise data were LGBTQ portrayals.

Context Corner: The Queerness of Minor Roles

Looking at the top 100 grossing films from 2024, USC Annenberg's Inequality in 1,800 Popular Films Report found that only 18 of the 100 films included LGBTQ+ characters. But even this overstates the prominence of LGBTQ+ roles. Among those 100 films, **less than 1% of characters with speaking roles were LGBTQ+**. This is especially troubling in light of the recent Trevor Project finding that seeing LGBTQ representation in TV/film is the **number one thing** that makes LGBTQ+ youth feel good about their identity.

Characters who are not relatable

Relatability goes hand-in-hand with authentic representation, according to adolescents. Portraying characters with diverse identities with specificity can help audiences get to know and relate to them as individuals, especially when they are given characteristics that young audiences see in themselves.



Spotlight: KPop Demon Hunters

For example, *K-Pop Demon Hunters* (2025) presents characters with personality traits that youth can easily identify with. The movie gives each of the three main characters distinct visual styling and explores their individual struggles in their song verses - a combination which imbues each of them with distinctiveness and relatability. In a particularly clever move, even though the main characters are idols themselves, they consistently show respect for their fans and even engage in fandom themselves. These sequences ground the girls, inviting K-Pop fans watching the movie to relate to them and adding to their authenticity.

> K-Pop Demon Hunters exemplified authentic character development, with characters whose distinct personalities and emotional depth made them feel like real people. Because their identities were so well-grounded, their stories became universal, making it easy for any viewer to relate to their journey, while those of Korean descent felt seen and represented accurately and authentically. - Sarina Marzbani, 17, Middle Eastern, California

Are stereotypes not a fatal flaw?

20.7%
of respondents cited stereotypes as the main flaw

No: Adolescents frequently cited stereotypes as the main flaw: **20.7%** of respondents, over six points higher than any other identified flaw. But stereotypes tended to not be a fatal flaw for representation. When they noted that the franchise's main flaw was stereotypicality, **it did not lead to lower AIR ratings.** Even more persuasively, when adolescents rated how stereotypical the franchise's representation was on a 5-point scale, that rating did not correlate with AIR scores at all - in other words, more stereotypicality did not change overall ratings of the representation. This speaks to the complexity of stereotypes: if not approached carefully, they can be very harmful, but when stereotypical characters are **treated with respect or given three-dimensional characteristics**, such as the "tiger mom" in *Turning Red*, they can also be part of authentic representation.

What can help?

Grounding characterization in authentic relationships

Adolescents who said that they connected especially strongly with a character because the character has a "relationship(s) that reminds me of relationship(s) in my own life" also rated those franchises very highly - an average of **3.81** out of 5, nearly to "Somewhat well" on the scale (that led to over $100 million higher box office earnings on average). This was meaningfully higher than when characters' personality traits, story arcs, etc. were most relatable to respondents.

Providing diverse characters with meaningful (platonic, familial, or romantic) relationships can help avoid many of the fatal flaws. If the characters have a shared identity, the culture of that identity can be conveyed through the relationship in a way that feels lived in and real. If the relationship is a focus of the story, that gives the story an opportunity to give both characters meaningful roles. If the relationship is written well, it can help audiences understand and relate to the characters.

Spotlight: Frozen



Disney's *Frozen* franchise is a strong example of how relationships can increase character relatability and authenticity. When asked which character they related to the most in the Frozen films, most adolescents chose either Elsa or Anna, with a relatively even split between them. The relationship between the two sisters is central to the plot of both films and defines many of the characteristics for the two characters. Older siblings may relate to Elsa's burden of responsibility, emotional restraint, and fear of harming those she loves. Younger siblings may resonate with Anna's desire to prove herself, loyalty, and longing for closeness. This relatable sibling bond is likely a big part of why **Frozen was one of the franchises whose representation (of women) adolescents rated significantly more highly than experts did**.

Why does AIR matter? Authentic representation leads to stronger audience connections with characters

In our data, we found that franchises with higher AIR ratings also lead adolescents to connect with characters more. For franchises, strong character connections can drive merchandising sales. This means **authentic representation likely not only leads to higher box office sales but increases merchandising opportunities**, impacting franchise revenue at every level.

CONCLUSION

The findings in this report make a simple but powerful case: adolescents are not just a core audience for franchise films — they are sophisticated judges of their diverse representation. They notice when a culture is rendered with depth and care, when a character is given a meaningful story rather than a tokenizing cameo, and when the people on screen feel like actual human beings with relationships worth caring about. And when they find representation that meets that bar, they show up — at the box office, in merchandise sales, and in the fandoms that sustain a franchise for the long term.

The throughline at the heart of these findings is something studios already know but don't always act on: authenticity is an asset, not a constraint. Adolescents with lived experience (those judging representation of their own identity) carry an expertise that develops early - 13-year-olds already have it. That means elevating teen perspectives in the development process; if they share the identity being represented, their read on authenticity is highly predictive of box office success, arguably even more than the expert consultants studios typically rely on. The three fatal flaws adolescents identified (a lack of cultural grounding, minimal roles for diverse characters, and characters who don't feel relatable) are all correctable. And there is a clear path forward: center real, culturally-embedded relationships. When diverse characters have meaningful bonds with one another that bring out their identities, it lays the groundwork for representation that even adolescents consider authentic. Authentic representation drives stronger connections to the franchise, and that connection drives success.

The franchises adolescents rated most highly (and that performed best at the box office) didn't just feature diverse characters. They built worlds around them that included people they loved and authentic cultural elements, and let all of those things help inform the story.

At CSS, our guiding principle is the same one that produced these findings: ask young people good questions and take their answers seriously. For storytellers and executives looking to build franchises that last, we're here to help bridge that gap, because when the industry listens to adolescents, everyone wins.

CONCLUSION

For studios who want to act on these findings, here are **four concrete tips**:

1. **Consult young people during production.** Adolescents, especially those with lived experience of the identity being represented, are strong judges of authentic representation that will resonate, and their demographic is key to franchise success.

2. **Be wary of the three fatal flaws.** During writing and production, ask whether the representation in your film has genuine cultural grounding, whether diverse characters have meaningful roles, and whether audiences have the chance to relate to those characters.

3. **Don't be afraid to make relationships the center of the story.** Relationships between friends, family members, and even romantic relationships can help illustrate the specificity of culture and identity that mark great representation.

4. **Build adolescent representation assessment into testing.** Adding an explicit measure of perceived authentic representation, especially when your sample includes adolescents, could help predict success for your film and any future installments.

Spotlight: YMR

CSS is committed to amplifying youth perspectives and empowering young voices through our Youth Media Representation (YMR) program. The YMR program creates a pipeline for authentic youth perspectives to reach the creators shaping their media worlds. By amplifying these voices, YMR promotes more inclusive, accurate representation in media and empowers teens to advocate for themselves and their communities. This work not only benefits participants but also helps support leaders in the entertainment industry to accurately reflect the realities of diverse youth today. For information about our YMR program, follow here!

METHOD

Project Description:

The purpose of this study was to test whether adolescents are an important and potentially overlooked authority on diverse representation in modern film, especially for franchises whose success depends on young people.

To conduct this study, CSS partnered with global insights and strategy firm, National Research Group (NRG), to survey 12,180 adolescents aged 13-24 via syndicated tracking. Franchise IQ is NRG's always-on syndicated tracker focused on entertainment franchises. It is in the field every week in the US, interviewing 3,500 general entertainment consumers per week. Semi-annually fielding 5,000 consumers internationally, FIQ has conducted over 1.3 million interviews globally with measurement on nearly 1,300 franchises. These franchises have touchpoints across key verticals including toys, gaming, streaming, television, and theatrical. Each franchise, including those featured in this report, is defined holistically - when respondents are asked about Spider-Man, for example, they are answering about their feelings toward the Spider-Man franchise as whole, encompassing its comics, movies, television series, etc.

Utilizing NRG's Franchise IQ, we asked adolescent respondents who were familiar with any of 29 popular franchises to rate the representation of a specific identity group portrayed in that franchise. To select the 29 franchises, we had four criteria: first, the franchise had to be currently tested by our data collection partner NRG; second, the franchise had to be represented in our AIR ratings so that we could make comparisons between AIR ratings and adolescents' ratings, third, the franchise had to include a film that was released in the past ten years, and fourth, no R-rated movies given the younger participants in the study. These criteria narrowed it down to 29 franchises and ratings of representation of six identities: Black, Hispanic/Latinx, Asian American-Pacific Islander, Indigenous/Native, Women, and LGBTQ+. For seven of the franchises, we had expert ratings of multiple identities, so there were a total of 38 rated identities.

We asked about racial, gender, and LGBTQ+ representation - specifically, portrayals of Black, Hispanic/Latinx, Asian American-Pacific Islander, Indigenous/Native, Women, and LGBTQ+ people. For adolescents who were familiar with the franchise, we asked them to rate the type(s) of representation portrayed in that franchise on a 5-point scale using two questions:

1. "How much does this franchise represent [identity group] culture or [identity group] people in a good or positive, realistic, or three-dimensional way?"

2."*'Authentically inclusive representation' of [identity group] people means portraying both [identity group] individuals and their culture prominently in the movie, in a way that is genuine and respectful. This means a [identity group] viewer would feel understood by the movie, seeing themselves and their culture accurately represented.* Overall, how well did the movie include authentically inclusive representation of [identity group] people that felt real and complex?

We calculated each participant's AIR Rating using the average of their scores on these two questions. To get a clearer picture of why they rated the franchise the way they did, we asked three follow-up questions:

- "How much does this franchise include stereotypes about [identity group] people that some might consider problematic or harmful?"
- "Which character do you relate to the most?" "Why?" [Six options: The character's relationship(s), personality trait(s), story arc, likability, uniqueness, or shared identity]
- "Choose the option that best describes the biggest flaw with the representation of [identity group] people:" [Six options: The identity group's minimal role, stereotypical characteristics, lack of real or relatable characters, problematic or unrealistic relationships, inauthentic story arc, or lack of authentic cultural representation]

Franchises:

Our pool of franchises had varying average production budgets. The mega-blockbusters like Avatar and Black Panther ranged from the $180-300 million ballpark while low-budget franchises like Crazy Rich Asians and Tyler Perry's Madea ranged from $8-30 million. Overall, the average production budget of the 29 selected films is $130 million. The average domestic box office across the franchises is $282 million. Our pool included 32.1% animated to 67.9% live action films, and the MPA rating of the films was 35.7% PG and 64.3% PG-13– notably, no rated-R films were included. We had 6 identities represented in our pool at different frequencies: Indigenous (3.44%), Latinx (17.24%), Women (48.26%), Black (17.24%), AAPI (20.69%), and LGBTQ+ (20.69%). The top three most recognized franchises, with the largest sample sizes were Coco, Wreck-it-Ralph, and Spider-Verse.

Avatar	Captain Marvel	Fantastic Beasts	Moana	The Hunger Games
Barbie	Coco	Fast & Furious	Ocean's Eight	The Jungle Book
Barbie	Crazy Rich Asians	Frozen	Spider-Verse	Thor
Black Panther	Creed	Incredibles	Strange World	Tyler Perry's Madea
Blue Beetle	Doctor Strange	Knives Out	The Batman	Ultraman: Rising
Bob's Burgers	Downton Abbey	Minions: The Rise of Gru	The Color Purple	Wreck-It Ralph

Participants:

Our final sample included 23,284 participants ranging in age from 13 to 24 years old. Participants ranged broadly across this age span, with representation from each age cohort between 13 and 24. Each age category had a minimum of 1,017 participants in it. Additionally, each franchise had at least 485 participants who rated it. The racial composition of the sample included respondents identifying as White (54.4%), Hispanic and/or Latino (20.9%), Black or African American (15.8%), Native American or Indigenous (4.5%), Asian or Asian American (2.5%), and Middle Eastern or North African (1.0%), with smaller proportions identifying as another race (0.6%) or preferring not to answer (0.2%). Overall, 2.5% of respondents identified as multiracial. Regarding gender, 50.5% of participants identified as female, 48.4% as male, and 1.2% identified as another gender identity or preferred not to answer. In terms of sexual orientation, 35.5% identified as heterosexual/straight, 8.0% as bisexual, and 2.7% as gay or lesbian, while smaller proportions identified as other (0.8%) or questioning (1.1%), and 52.0% of respondents preferred not to disclose their sexual orientation.

Acknowledgments:

We would like to deeply thank the following contributors:

- To the National Research Group (NRG), whose data powered this research.
- To the Funders for Adolescent Science Translation (FAST), for supporting this research.
- To Whitney Jackson, whose design elevated and brought to life this important research.
- To Haidy Mendez and Nina Linhales Barker, whose web design and coordination made dissemination of this report possible.
- To every adolescent participant who lent their voices toward this research. We hope that you feel seen and heard through this report.

For more information about the methods or details about this study, please contact us at info@scholarsandstorytellers.com.



Have a follow-up question?

All of our findings from this project will be built into AskYalda, our new AI-powered research tool for storytellers!

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